

Speaker 1 [00:00:05] In this interview we are going to ask you several questions to find out more about your views on romantic relationships. We believe that your experience and perspective can contribute a lot to this project. Before we start, I would like to ask you, do you agree to participate in the study in accordance with the informed consent form I sent you yesterday?

Speaker 2 [00:00:26] Yes.

Speaker 1 [00:00:27] Okay. First I will ask you a few demographic questions, how old are you?

Speaker 2 [00:00:32] I'm [20-25] years old.

Speaker 1 [00:00:34] How long have you been with your partner?

Speaker 2 [00:00:37] About [<1 year].

Speaker 1 [00:00:40] Do you have children?

Speaker 2 [00:00:42] No.

Speaker 1 [00:00:44] Who do you live with at home?

Speaker 2 [00:00:47] I live with my family.

Speaker 1 [00:00:50] Can we explain a little bit more? Mom and dad?

Speaker 2 [00:00:52] I live with my mom and dad.

Speaker 1 [00:00:54] Okay. What is your main source of income or your current job?

Speaker 2 [00:01:00] My family.

Speaker 1 [00:01:02] And are you a [occupation]?

Speaker 2 [00:01:07] I am a [occupation], yes.

Speaker 1 [00:01:09] Okay. How would you like me to address your partner? For example, lover, spouse, boyfriend, partner. Which one do you prefer?

Speaker 2 [00:01:19] Lover, boyfriend. All of them, both of them.

Speaker 1 [00:01:26] Now I'm going to ask questions in a more romantic context. Can you tell me the story of how you met and how your relationship started?

Speaker 2 [00:01:38] We met on [Social Media] when I was in [Country] and it was our first meeting after I came back to [Country]. Our first meeting lasted about [1-5] days. We said, if it lasts [1-5] days, it's probably going well. And so on.

Speaker 1 [00:01:58] How would you rate the quality of your relationship compared to your friends' relationships?

Speaker 2 [00:02:10] I don't know if I've ever thought of it that way, as quality. How should I answer that, is there a choice or something?

Speaker 1 [00:02:20] I mean, it's not like a choice, but when you think about the relationships of your friends, the people around you, how do you position your own relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:02:30] I mean, I don't see it very differently, to be honest. I mean, if my friends have relationships, most of them don't, but the ones they have are usually good and long relationships. I see mine as close to them.

Speaker 1 [00:02:46] So do you see the quality of the relationship as similar, your relationship and your friends' relationships?

Speaker 2 [00:02:55] I mean, I see a better quality. Yes.

Speaker 1 [00:02:58] So can I ask you why you think that?

Speaker 2 [00:03:02] How can I put it, in the relationships of my other friends, the man should always take it down, the woman is more coy. We don't have that kind of thing. You know, both sides are both coy and should be more submissive. Everything is very equal, so I mean, it cannot be compared on that side, I think it is a different situation.

Speaker 1 [00:03:27] Thank you very much. May I ask how many romantic relationships you had in the past?

Speaker 2 [00:03:34] I think [1-5] romantic relationships. Yes. [1-5] with this one.

Speaker 1 [00:03:39] And how would you rate the quality of your current relationship compared to your previous relationships?

Speaker 2 [00:03:51] Definitely more. Maybe that's why it lasts so long.

Speaker 1 [00:03:57] So can I ask you why you think that here?

Speaker 2 [00:04:03] It's a different situation compared to other relationships, I mean compared to girl-boy relationships. How should I put it, the other people I'm in a relationship with are trying to do everything in secret, especially because we live in [Country]. In general, if we are going to meet like this, let's meet alone or if we are going somewhere, let's not hold hands, let's not stand side by side, let's not be obvious or something like that. There is nothing like that right now, so I can't compare that situation with others at all. This is the first time I am in this kind of relationship right now.

Speaker 1 [00:04:39] What do you mean by this kind of relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:04:41] There is always a concern to stay hidden.

Speaker 1 [00:04:47] So what makes a relationship high quality for you?

Speaker 2 [00:04:53] I mean, I think that both sides understand each other. Or that something doesn't remain stable, doesn't get stuck in a routine.

Speaker 1 [00:05:03] Can we say that then? Can we say that high quality relationships are those in which both parties understand each other, which are not bound by routine?

Speaker 2 [00:05:15] I think yes.

Speaker 1 [00:05:17] So can you tell me in this context how one knows that one is in an understanding relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:05:27] How does it show that you're understanding? For example.

Speaker 1 [00:05:35]. So for example, a person knows how to be in an understanding relationship.

Speaker 2 [00:05:44] For example, in my old relationships, if my partner wanted to do something, it was done. If I wanted to do something, I was usually discouraged. Now, for example, he also gives up something. He does something I want to do even if he doesn't want to do it. I do something I don't want to do because he does it.

Speaker 1 [00:06:08] So for example, when would you say your relationship was understanding or when was it not understanding, understanding?

Speaker 2 [00:06:18] In my current relationship, I've never come across anything like that, he's always been very understanding.

Speaker 1 [00:06:26] Okay. And what do you think makes a relationship of lower quality?

Speaker 2 [00:06:35] Lower quality. Anything that restricts each other I think lowers the quality.

Speaker 1 [00:06:45] Okay, thank you very much. What is love according to you?

Speaker 2 [00:06:54] I didn't really know how to answer.

Speaker 1 [00:06:57] Yes, it's a bit difficult question.

Speaker 2 [00:06:59] I think love (aşk) is temporary, it's a feeling that you get at first. It's a cliché but I don't think it's a healthy thing. I think love (sevgi) and respect are more important. Of course everyone should experience it. It's a beautiful thing.

Speaker 1 [00:07:17] So why do you think love is unhealthy?

Speaker 2 [00:07:22] Because of course I don't know if I've been in love one hundred percent, but if I have been, I think that if I'm going to do something, that's my only focus at that moment, for example. I have school, my classes, my family, some other problems, my friends. So I think that becomes my only focus in that situation. And this of course causes everything to go wrong. That's why.

Speaker 1 [00:07:46] So how important do you think love is in a relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:07:51] I mean, I think it is enough that it exists although it does not last too long.

Speaker 1 [00:07:55] Okay. How do you know if your partner loves you?

Speaker 2 [00:08:06] I mean, how to put it. I can tell from his every sentence that he is thinking about me. Even when we go somewhere, if he arranges something, he usually does most of the things with me in mind. Of course, not always in a way that restricts his own life. For example, if we are going to do something together, he usually shows that he thinks about me in every detail. For example, we will go somewhere like this because that's how I feel comfortable.

Speaker 1 [00:08:33] What would you say are the challenges in your relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:08:49] At the beginning we had a lot of financial problems. It doesn't seem to be a problem in a relationship, but we had financial differences. This was even a problem. He was voicing it and I was on the contrary, this decision is my decision. You know, if I want to stay in trouble, I stay, if I don't want to stay, I don't stay. That's it. It continues like that now, but it was a really difficult period. How can I put it, if there is something I want to do, I can't do it because I was thinking like he can't do it. Of course, we don't think like that anymore. That's a different time.

Speaker 1 [00:09:36] So do you and your partner fight?

Speaker 2 [00:09:40] We don't fight, but when we sulk and argue, it takes about a minute.

Speaker 1 [00:09:49] So for example, how often do these fights or sulks happen?

Speaker 2 [00:09:56] It happens often and I like it too, no lie. It happens every day.

Speaker 1 [00:10:06] So for example, what are these sulks or fights usually about?

Speaker 2 [00:10:12] It can be about very silly things. We had a friend at school. He is a friend who is unnecessarily friendly to everyone. I don't see him, but he my friend on [Social Media], for example, because I don't want to remove a person I see all the time, it would be weird, he may ask "why did you remove it" when I see him. My partner said why don't you remove him if you are uncomfortable. We didn't talk for a while, he doesn't look at me or something. I don't know how to explain it.

Speaker 1 [00:10:47] Okay, I kind of understand. So for example, how do you usually solve these fights or sulks?

Speaker 1 [00:10:56] I don't know much to be honest. It resolves itself, I look at him, we start laughing and it's over. It takes a very short time. I say one or two minutes maximum.

Speaker 1 [00:11:11] So for example, what do you think are the other ways to maintain a relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:11:18] Other ways to maintain a relationship. What do you mean by that?

Speaker 1 [00:11:21] What do you think is necessary to maintain a relationship? You said earlier to show understanding. You said that when we fight, we laugh and we are like before. What do you think is necessary to maintain a relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:11:37] I think it is necessary to be very open, I mean how can I put it. I think nothing is solved when you say something that you don't want to say. If it's going to take a long time, I think it's taking a long time for nothing. Either it should end immediately or it should last. So I'm a little bit against doing anything to make a relationship last longer.

Speaker 1 [00:12:00] Would you say that this relationship is good for you?

Speaker 2 [00:12:04] Yes, I would say so.

Speaker 1 [00:12:05] And why do you think so?

Speaker 2 [00:12:09] First of all, it really helped me both in my relationships with friends and with my family. I mean, how can I say, I feel more peaceful and self-confident, yes. There is a person who has the same goal as me. So if I want to do something, he wants to do the same thing with me in the future. I think I am now with someone I would always want to be with.

Speaker 1 [00:12:37] Can you give some more concrete examples about these goals?

Speaker 2 [00:12:50] For example, we all want to go and live in the same country after graduation. He wants to do something there and I want to do something there. I thought that would be the most concrete example.

Speaker 1 [00:13:04] You support each other in this regard.

Speaker 2 [00:13:08] Yes.

Speaker 1 [00:13:11] So do you think this relationship has changed you?

Speaker 2 [00:13:14] Yes, absolutely.

Speaker 1 [00:13:16] In what way?

Speaker 2 [00:13:20] We had a very short, one and a half, two-week separation period for financial reasons. Actually, it's not a separation, we talked and saw each other every day, but we said we were separated. This separation period happened in the [1st-5th] month. How can I say that? In the past, I used to strive for someone to stay in my life like this, I used to make efforts, I used to put myself in difficulty. Now I don't. I think I have changed myself a lot in this regard.

Speaker 1 [00:13:56] So do you think your partner changed during the relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:14:01] Yes, he changed. He used to have a lot of tensions, that could get angry and upset immediately, that could be offended by everything I did, and now, as I explained it, he gradually changed himself a lot in this way. He takes everything very lightly, even I feel shocked.

Speaker 1 [00:14:25] Okay. So do you feel safe in this relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:14:28] Yes.

Speaker 1 [00:14:32] Can you explain a little bit more why you say that?

Speaker 2 [00:14:33] But what kind of trust are we talking about now?

Speaker 1 [00:14:37] For example, being able to open up to your partner about your experiences, thoughts and identity without fear of judgment or retaliation. Or knowing that your partner will offer you comfort and compassion in times of danger and distress.

Speaker 2 [00:14:52] Yes, I think about that, because he has always been there for me. There's never been a time when he hasn't been. Even in the most irrelevant situation, he is always there for me.

Speaker 1 [00:15:03] Now I'm going to share a screen with you and I'm going to ask you if my partner usually really listens to me. On a scale of 1 to 9.

Speaker 2 [00:15:32] Seven.

Speaker 1 [00:15:37] What if I asked you my partner is usually sensitive to my needs?

Speaker 2 [00:15:43] Always a nine on this one.

Speaker 1 [00:15:58] You gave a seven on my partner really listens to me. Can you give some concrete examples of when this happens?

Speaker 2 [00:16:12] I can't think of many, but let me think. He takes everything I say seriously and tries to act accordingly. How can I give a concrete example?

Speaker 1 [00:16:29] For example, when was the last time you felt like this? Maybe you can give such an example. The last time I felt that he was really listening to me was like this.

Speaker 2 [00:16:42] There are many times when I tell very empty things. I am talking, I am talking and he is there listening. I don't talk about anything to be taken very seriously. Then, I don't remember if it was [6-10] months or [6-10] months ago, he made a dish, I don't remember exactly what it was, and he put something mixed with bayleaf on it. A normal person wouldn't put that on it. He put something mixed with bayleaf and herbs. I asked him how he remembered because I don't even remember telling him about it. He listened to me telling him about it [6-10] months ago. That's a ridiculous example.

Speaker 1 [00:17:22] I think it's a very good example. For example, why did you give 7 and not 6 or 8?

Speaker 2 [00:17:35] I mean, we must have missed something, and of course we do. But there are no situations to be taken very seriously.

Speaker 1 [00:17:54] You gave me to the statement that my partner is usually sensitive to my needs. Can you give some concrete examples of this?

Speaker 2 [00:18:07] He is very sensitive to me and he tries to prevent anything in advance that would hurt me or make me upset about anything. Even in my own circle of friends. If I told him about someone I was annoyed with before, for example, if he heard from someone else that he was going to come to an event, he warns them from the beginning and tries to do something in some way. I don't know if this is an example but he is always really sensitive.

Speaker 1 [00:18:38] I hope you don't mind me asking this question and if it's too sensitive for you to share please feel free to say so. But we also wanted to know a little bit about our physical intimacy as a couple. How often do you have sexual intercourse these days?

Speaker 2 [00:18:55] Well I've been in [Country] for [1-5] week so he's not here but before that how should I specify this frequency?

Speaker 1 [00:19:04] I mean, for example, like this many times a week.

Speaker 2 [00:19:08] It varies 3-4, sometimes 7.

Speaker 1 [00:19:18] So how satisfied are you with your sex life?

Speaker 2 [00:19:22] I am very satisfied.

Speaker 1 [00:19:24] So for example, what would you say about the place of sexuality in a relationship? Do you think it is important or unimportant?

Speaker 2 [00:19:32] I think it is one of the most important things. Because when I meet, of course, I don't meet anyone by knowing their insides, I meet them by seeing their outward appearance. How do I know what's inside, I haven't seen it, but it seems strange to me that a relationship can continue without sexuality. There must be people who do it, but I can't do it.

Speaker 1 [00:19:57] Okay, now I will share a screen with you again. How satisfied are you with your relationship in general? In line with these options.

Speaker 2 [00:20:14] I am very satisfied. I mean, I don't have any problems right now. Of course we fight, we argue, but it is solved immediately. That's why I think it's better.

Speaker 1 [00:20:33] Okay then. I get the answer that I am very satisfied.

Speaker 2 [00:20:43] These answers will not be told to the partner, right?

Speaker 1 [00:20:45] No, no, absolutely not. It stays with us. So, for example, how would you rate your satisfaction with your relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:20:57] Let's say 9 like the other question.

Speaker 1 [00:21:09] So why did you answer 9 for example?

Speaker 2 [00:21:14] I mean, of course I am satisfied, but there are of course things. For example, it doesn't always come to my mind that I am annoying the other person, of course, such things don't always come to my mind, but it happens, that's why. We both have aspects that we both need to change. Nobody is perfect, after all. Look at me for example.

Speaker 1 [00:21:35] For example, in the context of this relationship, what aspects do you see in your partner or yourself that you need to change?

Speaker 2 [00:21:44] First of all, I think my partner is a person who can immediately rise to everything, who can be so enthusiastic. He is also a person who can be very nervous all the time. I

think this needs to change. He says this himself and people around him too. I think this is something that needs to change. Other than that, I don't have anything else.

Speaker 1 [00:22:09] Hmm. So can we say this then? Can we say that the fact that your partner can get up easily and sometimes get down easily can sometimes reduce the quality of your relationship at times?

Speaker 2 [00:22:19] Yes.

Speaker 1 [00:22:23] So, for example, why did you answer 9 and not 8 or 10 to the previous question? I didn't give 10 because there are these things, I didn't give 8 because there are these things.

Speaker 2 [00:22:36] I didn't give 10 because of the reason I just explained. I didn't give 8 because I don't see it as a big problem. It's very easily solved when something happens. He is a very easy person to solve problems.

Speaker 1 [00:23:03] For example, in one of the previous questions, did you say that open communication is very important during some arguments. In these fights or in situations where your partner gets tense very easily, do you solve them with open interaction or do you apply different strategies in solving these fights?

Speaker 2 [00:23:25] No, I have never practiced alternative strategies, he is usually with me. We solve it this way by talking.

Speaker 1 [00:23:31] So for example, how do the reactions from your partner affect your relationship quality? For example, when my partner does this behavior during an argument, my relationship quality increases, but when my partner does that behavior, my relationship quality decreases.

Speaker 2 [00:24:01] If we are disagreeing face to face, for example, I think it decreases the quality when he suddenly rises up and constantly emphasizes a subject, saying it one after another. You know, after a while I start to get annoyed. I always like it when he shows some kind of undercutting characteristic. I think it raises the quality. I think it's something that everyone should do, not only in my relationship but also with my friends.

Speaker 1 [00:24:35] We are about to finish now, but I wanted to give a brief summary of what we talked about in the last half an hour. If you want to add, if there is a part you say is missing, we can add it again. You said that you are [20-25] years old and you have been with your partner for [<1 year]. You met about [<1 year] in [Country] through [Social Media]. When you returned to [Country], you spent [1-5] days together and then continued with your partner. You said that's how you met. Compared to your friends, you said that sometimes you saw your relationship as better quality and sometimes as equal. Here, especially when we compare it to your previous relationships, you said that your partners in your previous relationships usually tried to keep it secret, but in this relationship you can behave openly and comfortably. When I asked you what makes a relationship of high quality, you said that it should be understanding and not routine. When I asked you what makes a relationship of low quality, you said that it should be a relationship that does not restrict each other. When I asked you what love is according to you, you said that it is temporary, it is experienced at the beginning of the relationship, but it should not be too much, otherwise it is your only focus, you cannot think about your family, your work. When I asked you how important love is in a relationship, you said that it is enough that it happens. When I asked you how you can tell if your partner loves you, you said that he does everything he does with me in mind. When we came to the difficulties in the relationship, you mentioned financial difficulties. Often there is a period of tripping at the beginning of a relationship, but otherwise you don't fight much. You said that this is usually about everything, but that it resolves itself and that you laugh at each other and continue. When I asked you about other ways to keep the relationship going, you said that you needed to be open, that everyone should openly express their problems or opinions. You said that this relationship changed you in a positive way. It changed your perspective towards your family, towards your friends, towards your work. You also said that your partner also changed. You said that you felt safe in this relationship. That you can always see your partner by your side. That your partner was sensitive to your needs and prevented things that could harm you. For example, you said that when someone you don't like shows up during a date, he/she should try to prevent him/her from telling you at work immediately. You said that you are satisfied with your sex life and that sex is an important part of the relationship. We can summarize it as follows. Apart from that, is there anything else you would like to add?

Speaker 2 [00:28:48] Not much. I think I just sounded a bit cold, like he's always thinking about my needs, but it's a bit like that really. No need to fix it.

Speaker 1 [00:29:04] We can talk about other things that you perceive as sensitive. I mean, for example, how do you understand how you perceive some behaviors other than thinking about you as sensitive?

Speaker 2 [00:29:21] I'm a person who doesn't like apathy at all, same with my friends. So he knows that very well and he behaves accordingly. He knows that I don't want to be ignored and he always pays attention. He always calls, he always finds a way to contact me somehow. But you don't need to change it.

Speaker 1 [00:29:47] No, I'm not changing it, there is no right and wrong answer. After all, this is a conversation and a relationship is a concept that can change a lot and has a lot of dynamics.

Speaker 1 [00:30:06] Apart from that, my questions are over. But before I finish I would like to talk to you about how we will handle your data. As a research project we want to be as transparent as ethically possible. Therefore, we want to know which data sharing option is most suitable for you. The first option is to share only some specific parts of the transcript of our interview. None of these transcripts will contain any identifying information. This will ensure that your identity is changed and that your interview transcript can be read by other researchers.

The second option, if you don't mind and if you want to be a bit bolder, is to share the entire interview transcript, stripped of sensitive and overly identifying details, i.e. anonymized. In this option, there is a slim to none chance that someone who knows you will be able to piece together the details from the interview transcript and narrow down the options to include who they believe you are among their colleagues. Again, I would like to emphasize that no sensitive information will ever be shared. All your data will be shared strictly free of identifiers such as names. Which of these two options would you prefer?

Speaker 2 [00:31:34] So you can share everything as long as it's not my name and image.

Speaker 1 [00:31:38] Okay, thank you very much. And lastly, as I shared with you before, this study is also being done in other countries like Brazil, France and other countries like America, Philippines, and for this study to be successful, we have a request from you if it is suitable for you. Can you nominate two close people in your life? We will ask them to suggest other couples who might be interested in this study. I will also ask them to suggest couples that you don't know, couples that you don't interact with, so that we can reach more participants. Is this suitable for you?

Speaker 2 [00:32:20] So it's okay. If you want, I have friends as couples, but I think you mean couples who are not my friends.

Speaker 1 [00:32:29] If it is an LGBT couple, they can be too.

Speaker 2 [00:32:35] No, they are not.

Speaker 1 [00:32:37] Then maybe you can nominate your friend. They can then suggest other couples. We would be very happy if you can suggest two such people. Because it is also difficult to find some participants.

Speaker 2 [00:32:50] Now?

Speaker 1 [00:32:52] Later is fine, you can also send a message via [Social Media].

Speaker 2 [00:32:56] I don't know any LGBT people right now.

Speaker 1 [00:32:58] As I said, if you nominate a candidate, we will ask two people from your life to suggest a couple.

Speaker 2 [00:33:13] If you ask my boyfriend, he can give you a better answer if you want more people he knows.

Speaker 1 [00:33:18] Okay, I'll ask him too. But as I said, it would be very good for us if you suggest the person in your close circle or if we ask them to nominate a couple. You know, they don't need to participate, they will not participate in the study. They will only nominate three pairs of candidates.

Speaker 2 [00:33:40] Then it's like I tell you my friend and he recommends you a couple.

Speaker 1 [00:33:45] Yes. We can do that later via message. Apart from that, I will soon send you a survey via a link, a short survey that takes about ten minutes. I will ask you to fill in this survey with the code [code] because there is a part that asks for your name. You do not need to write your name there. If you write the code [code] there, in order to ensure that the data is anonymous and your name is not there. Thank you very much for participating. You can always contact me if you have any questions. I hope it was a pleasant meeting for you as well. Thank you very much again. See you then.

Speaker 2 [00:34:38] You are welcome, see you soon. Then I will fill in the questionnaire.

Speaker 1 [00:34:47] Thank you very much. See you soon.

Speaker 2 [00:34:49] Thank you. See you soon.